MAKE IT DO · FREE SHEET

What things cost the year you were born

1939

IN 1939	THE RECORD	TODAY	IN OUR HOUSE
A pound of white bread per pound	7.9¢	**$1.87** per pound	
A dozen eggs per dozen	32¢	**$4.25** per dozen	
Half a gallon of milk delivered to the door	24¢	**$2.03** half a gallon, at the store	
A pound of butter per pound	32¢	**$4.76** per pound	
A pound of round steak per pound	36¢	**$8.86** per pound	
A pound of bacon per pound	32¢	**$7.02** per pound	
A pound of coffee per pound	22¢	**$8.18** per pound	
Five pounds of sugar 5-pound bag	27¢	**$5.12** 5 pounds	
Ten pounds of potatoes 10-pound bag	25¢	**$9.63** 10 pounds	
A stamp for a letter first-class, first ounce	3¢	**82¢** Forever stamp	
An hour's pay at the federal minimum from Oct. 24, 1939	30¢	**$7.25** federal minimum since 2009	

THE NAMES IN THE HOSPITAL NURSERY, 1939

Girls: Mary, Barbara, Patricia, Betty, Shirley. **Boys:** Robert, James, John, William, Richard.

One dollar in 1939 buys about what **$23.16** buys today (consumer price index, 2025 average). The last column is yours: write in what it cost in your house.

Where every number comes from. U.S. Bureau of the Census, Historical Statistics of the United States, Colonial Times to 1970, Part 1, p. 213, series E 188, 189, 192, 193, 194, 195, 197, 200, 202 (retail food prices, BLS); United States Postal Service, Historian, "Rates for Domestic Letters Since 1863" (September 2021), Table "Postage in Cents, per Ounce" (effective dates), p. 1 (single-page PDF); U.S. Department of Labor, Wage and Hour Division, History of Federal Minimum Wage Rates Under the Fair Labor Standards Act, 1938-2009 (1938 Act column). Today: U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics average prices, 2025 average; USPS 2026.

From the Make It Do film
Everyday Life in 1950s America,
in Real Color Film